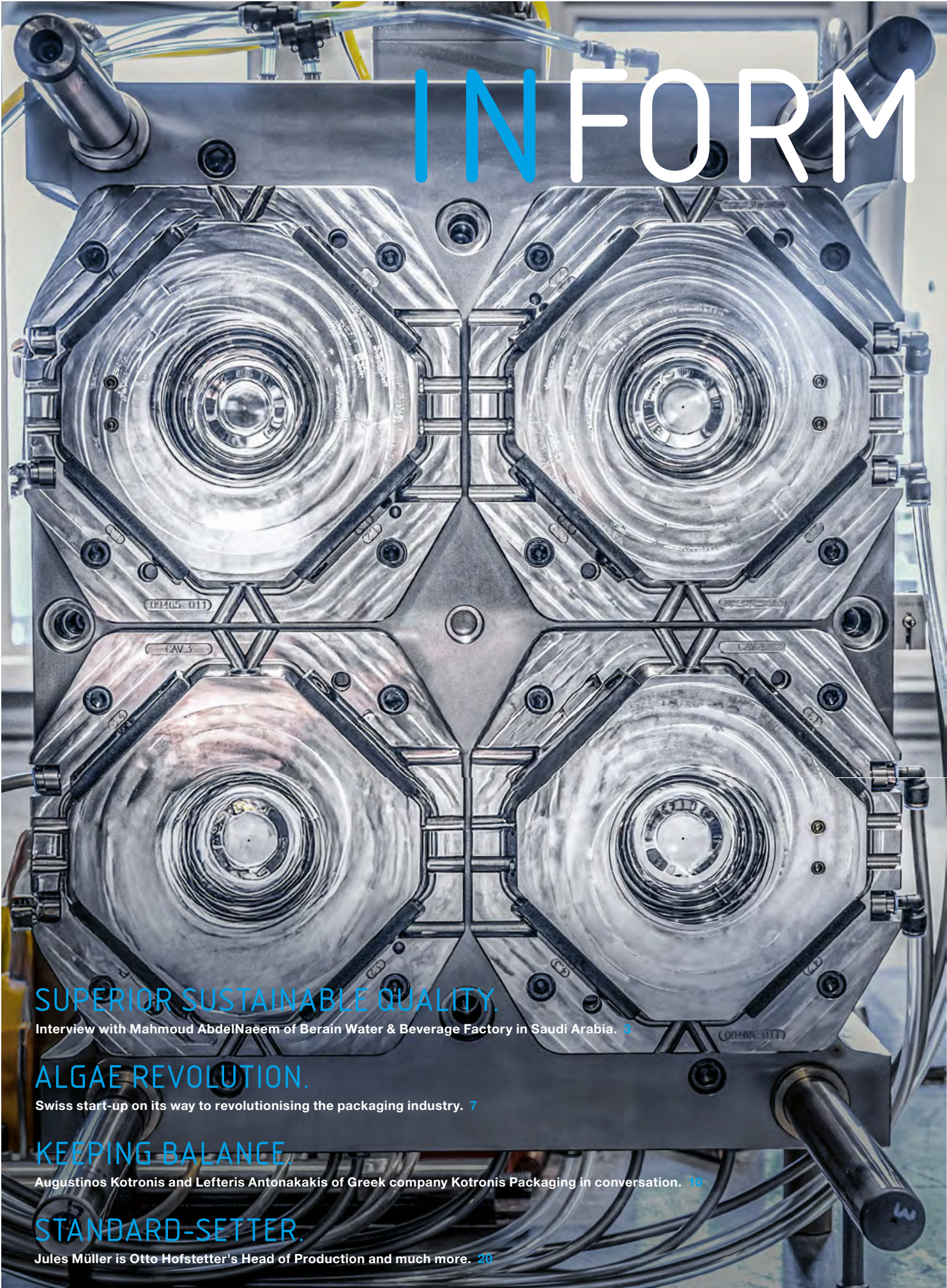




# INFORM

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# REASONS FOR CONFIDENCE.



Dear readers

I recently returned from India, where we celebrated the traditional ceremony for good karma in the new building of our branch there. It was a moving experience and I was most impressed by the enthusiasm and optimism of the team there.

This positive energy contrasts sharply with the current mood in the Swiss technology industry. The strong Swiss franc, the shortage of skilled workers and the pressure on margins due to high energy prices continue to pose challenges for us. Nevertheless, I am confident about the future of Otto Hofstetter AG. Here at our headquarters, six young people recently began their technical or commercial apprenticeships. Their curiosity and youthful energy are a guarantee for the future of our company and our industry.

At Otto Hofstetter AG, we continue to focus on developing solutions that meet the changing needs of our customers. We present one such solution to you in this issue of "inform". Together with our sister company Otto Systems, we have developed the new HOD-Series 160 production system that raises the bar for manufacturing large PET containers.

Forward movement is part of our DNA. It has shaped our activities since my father founded the company in 1955. I see this in the mentality of the people who work here. In an interview in this issue, our production manager, Jules Müller, says that the will to overcome challenges as a team seems to be innate in the people from our region and this makes many outcomes possible. I recommend that you read the entire interview. Then you will understand another source of my confidence.

Switzerland, with its tradition of openness to innovation, enjoys a healthy, future-oriented business climate. Start-ups are constantly springing up that provide inspiration and new dynamism. In this issue, we profile Noriware, one of these great young Swiss companies. With its renewable, algae-based innovations, this exciting start-up aims to kick off a sustainable revolution in the plastics industry.

I invite you to immerse yourself in the latest edition of "inform", our customer magazine, and I look forward to meeting you again in person soon.

Yours,  
Otto Hofstetter

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A portrait of Mahmoud AbdelNaeem, a man with short, graying hair, wearing a dark suit, white shirt, and a blue and gray striped tie. He is looking directly at the camera with a neutral expression. The background is a solid light blue.

# SUPERIOR SUSTAINABLE QUALITY AND MANUFACTURING EXCELLENCE

The **Berain Water & Beverages Factory**, a leading bottled water brand in **Saudi Arabia**, has its headquarters and two of its production facilities in Riyadh. A third plant is located in Jeddah. Operations Executive Director **Mahmoud AbdelNaeem** discusses the company and the Saudi bottled water market. He also presents **Berain Water's guiding philosophy**, which prioritises the **highest quality** in all its activities.

"OUR FACILITIES ARE EQUIPPED WITH  
HIGH-QUALITY INFRASTRUCTURE  
AND GLOBAL TECHNOLOGY."

Mahmoud AbdelNaeem,  
Operations Executive Director at Berain Water



## Understanding Berain Water

Founded in 2015, Berain Water and Beverage Factory began its operations the same year. Headquartered in Riyadh, the company operates three state-of-the-art manufacturing facilities – two in Riyadh and one in Jeddah. The company serves both domestic and international markets, offering a broad range of bottled water products in various sizes, including its iconic 200ml PET bottle, which was introduced to address consumer demand for portion-controlled packaging.

### A commitment to end-to-end quality

“At Berain, one of our core competitive advantages is our superior sustainable quality performance,” says AbdelNaeem. “We implement an end-to-end quality concept, ensuring the highest standards from the materials we use, through every step of our operations, to the final product available to consumers. This holistic approach covers the entire supply chain cycle – ‘the make, move, and sell’ – and sets us apart in the marketplace.”

### Saudi bottled water market: unique dynamics

“The Saudi bottled water market is unique,” AbdelNaeem explains. “Nearly the entire population relies on bottled water for domestic use, and with the growing number of visitors to the Kingdom, the demand continues to increase. In addition, the Saudi market is distinct in that glass bottles are used only once, unlike in European markets where reuse is common. This makes glass bottles in Saudi Arabia more exclusive and premium.”

### Market outlook and growth opportunities

The outlook for the Saudi bottled water market is highly positive, driven by local customs favouring bottled water and the increasing focus on health and wellness. “As quality of life in Saudi Arabia improves and more people become health-conscious, demand for premium bottled water like Berain continues to rise,” says AbdelNaeem. He highlights Berain’s commitment to the premium market segment, with its products available on national airlines, in five-star hotels, and at other first-class establishments.

### The driving vision: sustainable winning quality “Berain’s promise to consumers”

“Berain’s vision is to be the leading brand in drinking water

production and bottling, and that starts with our unwavering focus on quality,” AbdelNaeem states. “We strive to achieve excellence across all areas of our business, including our products, packaging, and customer service. Our facilities are equipped with high-quality infrastructure and global technology, and our team continuously trains to maintain these standards.”

### Looking Ahead: Expanding Reach and Embracing Sustainability

Berain is not only focused on local market growth but also on expanding its presence in the Gulf States. The company is also embracing sustainability, exploring ways to incorporate recycled PET (rPET) into its production while maintaining the highest quality standards. “Our commitment to sustainability extends to every part of our operation, from the materials we use to our long-term business practices,” AbdelNaeem concludes.

“We are proud of what we have achieved so far and are excited about the future of Berain Water as a leader in the premium bottled water market in Saudi Arabia.”

### You are certified as a Great Place to Work® company. What is your motivation to engage in this certification process?

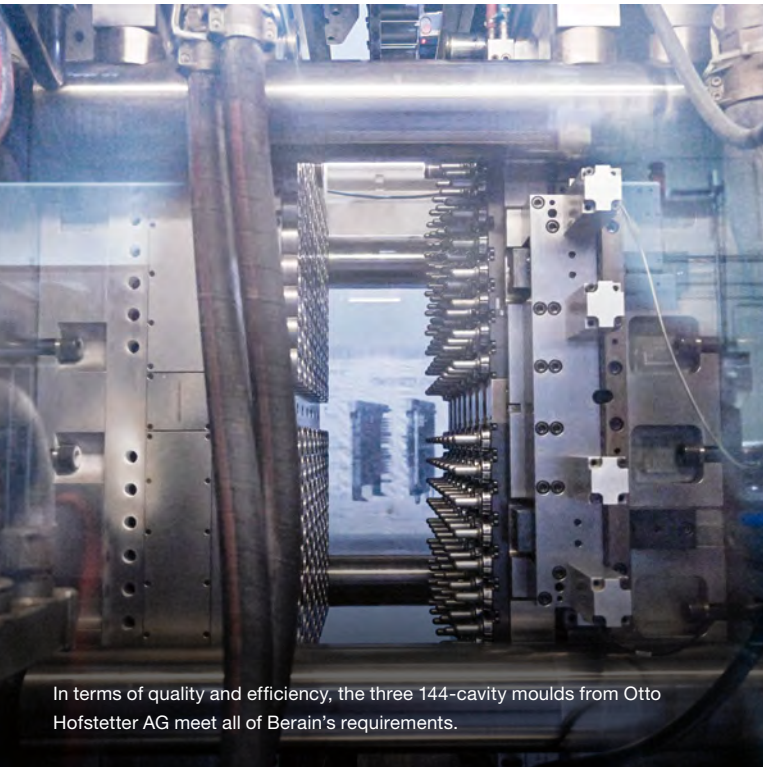
Our commitment to achieving the highest quality also means that, in order to attract top talent, we aim to be recognised as an appealing employer. Berain functions as a multinational corporation and, as such, seeks highly skilled individuals in technical areas, logistics, marketing, and sales. The Great Place to Work® certification serves as a vital tool in drawing premier talent to our organisation.

### Berain has been using preform moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG since early 2018. Why did you choose the Swiss supplier?

The decision to use moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG was made before I joined the company, but the quality and reliability of the Swiss moulds are well known in the industry, which provided a good starting point for our cooperation. And now, having gained experience with the moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG, I share this assessment. We use three 144-cavity moulds and they meet all our requirements in terms of quality and efficiency.

“NEARLY THE ENTIRE  
POPULATION IN SAUDI ARABIA  
RELIES ON BOTTLED WATER  
FOR DOMESTIC USE.”

Mahmoud AbdelNaeem,  
Operations Executive Director at Berain Water



In terms of quality and efficiency, the three 144-cavity moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG meet all of Berain's requirements.

**At the beginning of this year, you replaced a hot runner after 20 million cycles and you did this using the OH-Xchange programme. What was your experience like?**

The complete overhaul of a 144-cavity mould usually takes around 25 working days, assuming the necessary skilled technicians are available. With OH-Xchange, we were able to reduce downtime to just two days. This minimal interruption in operations has proven to be beneficial for us, as our efficiency has suffered only slightly. After the mould returned to operation, we quickly began producing at full capacity again.

**How did the exchange process go?**

The replacement hot runner was prepared in the factory in Uznach and delivered to our plant in Riyadh. On the day of the conversion, the technician from Otto Hofstetter AG inspected the replacement unit to ensure that no damage had occurred during transport. Together with our technical team, he then removed the old hot runner and installed the new one. At the same time, our employees were trained in maintenance and cleaning procedures by the Otto Hofstetter AG specialist. After successfully completing test runs and making some fine adjustments, the system was soon able to start operating again.

**Otto Hofstetter attaches great importance to keeping its employees for a long time. How important is personal contact for you?**

Personal contact with the employees of Otto Hofstetter AG is an important basis for successful cooperation for us. We

have built up a partnership with them and particularly value their flexibility and their extensive technical know-how. The trust built through these connections is an important factor for the continued cooperation we strive for.

**"PERSONAL CONTACT WITH OTTO HOFSTETTER AG IS AN IMPORTANT BASIS FOR SUCCESSFUL COOPERATION FOR US."**

Mahmoud AbdelNaeem,  
Operations Executive Director at Berain Water

**In which areas could Otto Hofstetter AG improve?**

The collaboration with the technicians and the quality of the moulds have fully met our requirements. Of course, every company has room for improvement. However, I believe that Otto Hofstetter AG knows its strengths and weaknesses and, like us at Berain, is constantly working to become even better. We would like to see more opportunities for the exchange of technical knowledge, either through visits or video conferencing. And if prices were to fall, we would of course have no objection.

**What are the next steps in the development of Berain Water Company?**

We will continue to work towards our goal of becoming the leading brand in water production and bottling in Saudi Arabia. We will do this by delivering the highest levels of quality in our products and our services. In addition, we are pursuing opportunities to expand our market and increase the processing of rPET.

**Thank you for this insightful conversation, Mr Abdel-Naeem. We wish you and Berain Water Company continued success in the future.**

**berain**  
بيرين

Berain Water & Beverages Factory  
[www.berain.com.sa](http://www.berain.com.sa)

Founded: 2015  
Specialist in: Premium brand in Saudi Arabia for high-quality still and sparkling water in bottles ranging in size from 0.2 to 5 litres  
Markets: Households, companies, tourism organisations and gastronomy

170 Street, New Second Industrial City Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

# THE ALGAE REVOLU- TION

With its **algae-based materials**, the Swiss start-up **Noriware** is pioneering **sustainable packaging solutions**. The company was founded in 2022 by **Jessica Farda and Stefan Grieder** with the aim of revolutionising the packaging industry. Their goal is to offer a viable, environmentally friendly **alternative to conventional plastics**.



Norifilm is a transparent, flexible packaging material for dry goods.

Algae play a central role in the global ecosystem, producing 30 to 50 percent of the world's oxygen and absorbing CO<sub>2</sub> from the atmosphere. Since they grow up to ten times faster than terrestrial plants, they require no land for cultivation and also no fertilisers. Algae also help reduce marine pollution by using nutrient-rich wastewater to form biomass and algae can also absorb heavy metals. In addition, by breaking down CO<sub>2</sub>, they can also help counteract ocean acidification and help stabilise the ocean's pH value.

Algae are also a nutrient-rich source of proteins, amino acids, minerals, vitamins and antioxidants. However, their potential is still under-utilised in the food sector, especially in Europe. If algae were added to animal feed, for example, methane emissions could be significantly reduced, which would have a positive impact on the environment.

#### **Packaging: another application for algae.**

Noriware is pioneering the development of sustainable packaging solutions. After just two years of research and development, the Swiss start-up already offers two promising products.

Norifilm is a transparent, flexible packaging material for dry goods. It has the same strength as conventional plastics and can be processed using standard plastics industry machines. The material is compostable at home and will biodegrade in two to twelve weeks, depending on the film's thickness.

Noricup is the first rigid application of Noriware. It offers stability and water resistance that is similar to conventional plastic cups. And, because it is made from algae and other natural materials, Noricup is also 100 percent compostable. Both products decompose completely in household compost systems without leaving any microplastic residue. This property alone represents a significant advance over many current bioplastic alternatives.

Encouraged by the success of this first rigid application, the young Swiss entrepreneurs have decided to shift away from the cup and concentrate their efforts on producing a granulate that opens up further application possibilities.

#### **A renewable natural resource.**

The algae from which Noriware obtains its polymers come from sustainable sources. They are specially cultivated to achieve maximum yields with minimal environmental impact. Grown in special algae farms that do not require any arable land, they do not compete in any way with food production. In addition, they require little freshwater compared to agricultural plants. Algae grow quickly and can be harvested several times a year, making them a rapidly renewable resource.

#### **A scalable solution that pays off.**

The production process for Noriware uses existing plastic manufacturing technology. This compatibility reduces the barriers for manufacturers who want to switch to more sustainable materials. Jessica Farda, co-founder and CEO of Noriware, explains: "Once at industrial scale, our product is extremely scalable. It can be produced at competitive costs. We have developed a packaging solution that is both ecological and economical."

#### **Entrepreneurship meets expertise.**

Noriware works with some renowned Swiss technical institutions, such as the ETH Zurich and the Universities of Applied Sciences Northwestern and East Switzerland. These partnerships give the young company access to state-of-the-art research facilities and a deep well of expert knowledge. And these collaborations help to accelerate the development of Noriware's technology and its product range.

Noriware is currently developing a granulate. This innovation aims to offer the conventional plastics industry an alternative to the bioplastics available today. Noriware's algae-based granulate opens up new possibilities for different areas of application and for numerous manufacturing processes.

**"WE ARE NOT JUST MAKING A PRODUCT, WE ARE PIONEERING A SUSTAINABLE FUTURE FOR THE PACKAGING INDUSTRY."**

Jessica Farda, co-founder and CEO of Noriware

#### **Taking the start-up's pace into the future.**

Noriware has secured pre-financing of over one million Swiss francs. The company has also received support from government and private organisations. The first commercial products are scheduled to hit the market this year. They aim to strike a balance between durability and environmentally friendly disposal.

The packaging industry is under increasing pressure to introduce sustainable solutions. Noriware's algae-based technology is paving the way in this direction. It can utilise existing manufacturing infrastructure with products that are much more environmentally friendly. This makes Noriware a potential game-changer in the field of bioplastics. Jessica Farda underlines the company's ambitious vision: "We are not just making a product, we are pioneering a sustainable future for the packaging industry."

Learn more about the Swiss start-up Noriware at [www.noriware.com](http://www.noriware.com)



Noriware's production process utilises existing plastic manufacturing technologies.

- **ALGAE PRODUCE 30–50 % OF THE WORLD'S OXYGEN AND ABSORB CO<sub>2</sub> FROM THE ATMOSPHERE**
- **UP TO 70% OF THE ALGAE MASS CAN CONSIST OF CARBON.<sup>1</sup>**

<sup>1</sup> <https://blog.bkd.lu.ch/hslu-mikroalgen-gegen-klimawandel/>

# KEEPING BALANCE.



Kotronis is now led by the second generation and the third generation is stepping up: Ioannis, Christos and Augustinos Kotronis



**Kotronis Packaging**, located near **Nafpaktos in western Greece**, is one of the country's leading producers of thin-walled packaging for the food industry. The **family-run business** continues to follow the **traditional values** of its founder as it meets the challenges of **modern markets**, advanced technologies and growing ecological demands. **CEO Augustinos Kotronis and Commercial Director Lefteris Antonakakis** explain how this balancing act is achieved.

**Mr Kotronis, we often read about new products or changes in management in company news releases. But you recently reported on the hiring of a person with disabilities. What is behind that?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** We have always maintained a close connection with our local community and society as a whole, and we have already successfully hired disabled employees in various departments. But recently, for the first time, we hired someone from the Alkioni association, a local nonprofit organisation dedicated to supporting people with disabilities. This organisation has done exceptional work over the past twenty years, and we have been supporting them financially for a long time. After overcoming some bureaucratic difficulties, we were able to hire Soula, who quickly demonstrated an extraordinary level of dedication and professionalism. The entire team is thrilled to have her with us, and we see this experience as a first step towards further hirings from this community. This initiative even earned us a Gold Award at Greece's Packaging Awards 2024. We were pleased to be recognised for our contribution to strengthening our local community and are proud of this award.

**"WE HAVE A STRONG  
CULTURE OF ACCEPTANCE  
AND SUPPORT  
WITHIN THE COMPANY."**

**Augustinos Kotronis, CEO Kotronis Packaging**

**How did your employees respond to their new colleague? Did you offer any specific training sessions before she joined?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** We have a strong culture of acceptance and support within the company, which made Soula's integration easy. We informed our employees about her background and they welcomed her with open arms. We believe this initiative contributes significantly to strengthening our company's culture.

**In addition to your social commitments, you are also strongly focused on digitalisation. You recently launched a project called Praccis. Can you tell us about it?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** Praccis stands for "Plastic Resin Automatic Central Conveying Intelligent System". It's a fully automated raw materials supply system that we have developed and installed. Our internal and external silos are now connected to the processing machines, automatically providing them with raw materials as needed. While such systems are not uncommon in the industry, in our case the implementation of this project had to overcome two major challenges. First, we had to install pipes and special equipment in existing buildings that were not designed for these

purposes. And second, and most important, we wanted to maintain the high degree of production flexibility that we think differentiates us from our competition. The result is probably the most sophisticated central conveying system in southeastern Europe. We think this will help us achieve our goals effectively for many years to come.

**You belong to the second generation at the helm of Kotronis. How has the company evolved since its beginnings?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** In the late 1950s, our father founded a company that produced traditional sesame bars. In 1970, he purchased his first injection moulding machine in order to manufacture a polystyrene container that would better preserve his products. This opened up many new possibilities and led to the decision, in 1971, to focus exclusively on plastic food packaging. This set us on a path of

continuous growth over the following years, with the involvement of and contributions from all family members. Today, we are a second-generation family business, with the third generation already starting to get involved. We focus on thin-walled packaging for the food industry and operate our plant on a 34,000-square-metre site, whereby 15,000 square metres are roofed. We employ around 250 people and produce approximately 600 million containers and lids annually.

**What specific products do you offer?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** We mainly produce thin-walled containers for foods such as yogurt cups and packaging for deli products. Our portfolio includes containers in various sizes and shapes from small-portion packs to larger containers for yogurt or spreads.

**In addition to product development, you are also very active in design. Kotronis has won several design awards in recent years. What's the secret to your success?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** Design plays a central role in our business. It's not just about aesthetics, but also about functionality, practicality and food protection. Our design and development department works closely with our customers to create customised packaging that stands out not only for its appearance but also for its efficiency and durability. This combination of attributes has earned us several awards in recent years.

**Lefteris Antonakakis:** Design is a challenge because there

are many technical aspects to consider. We also need to meet our customers' demands for high quality, practical and recyclable packaging, and their wish for distinctive designs. Our ability to understand each customer's specific needs, the market trends and the capabilities of current technologies enables us to design unique and efficient packaging solutions with high added value. The key to our success is the close collaboration between the different departments and the integration of our expertise into every step of the design process.

**Kotronis is one of the leading providers of food packaging in Greece. How is the export business doing?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** Approximately 50% of our packages are consumed abroad. About 15% of our production is exported directly, mainly to the Balkans and the Middle East. Another 35% is considered indirect exports and refers to the packaging of food products made in Greece exported to the international markets. We see an annual growth of around 10% in our export business, which is gratifying. However, we export fewer larger packages, as transportation costs play a significant role in that regard."

**How do you choose the markets for your export products?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** We focus on the compatibility of our

products with the needs of the respective market. Logistics costs are crucial, as is the market's potential. In some cases, it makes more sense to produce the products locally rather than to export them from Greece. However, many of our customers appreciate our flexibility and quick delivery times, which keeps us competitive even in more distant markets.

**You have a variety of certifications, including IMS/FDA for the US market. What other certifications do you have?**

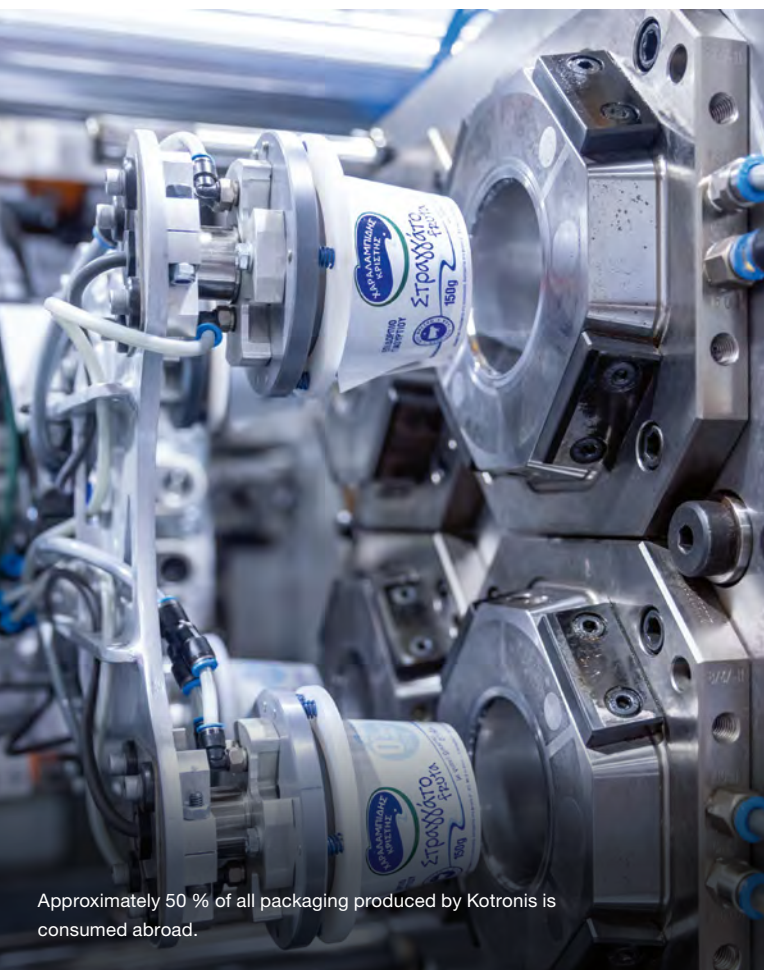
**Augustinos Kotronis:** Our company is committed to providing the highest quality products for food packaging. Therefore, in addition to IMS/FDA certification, we are certified according to several international standards. We hold both ISO 9001 and ISO 22000 as well as the BRCGS Packaging certification, which ensures food safety and product suitability for food packaging. Furthermore, we are certified to ISCC PLUS - an International Sustainability & Carbon Certification. This is based on the principles of the circular economy and recognises that we produce sustainable and environmentally friendly products and use certified renewable raw materials.

**What exactly is the SMETA/SEDEX certification that you also hold?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** SMETA stands for Sedex Members Ethical Trade Audit, and SEDEX stands for Supplier Ethical Data Exchange. These certifications confirm that we act



Kotronis values a close relationship with its employees and values their trust in their role.



Approximately 50 % of all packaging produced by Kotronis is consumed abroad.

responsibly, ethically and transparently. We obtained this certification at the request of a customer, and the auditor was impressed by our standards. We attach great importance to treating our employees fairly and adhering to ethical business practices. This is deeply rooted in our business culture, meaning that we always pursue a balanced approach in all areas. We inherited these values from our family, so it's natural for us to act ethically. Whenever an issue arises, we find the right and ethical solution to handle each situation appropriately.

**You also mentioned the EPD, the Environmental Product Declaration. How do you benefit from it?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** The Environmental Product Declaration allows us to accurately calculate the ecological footprint of each of our products. We conduct lifecycle analyses that are reviewed by external experts, and we create reports that help our customers make informed decisions. For example, we can say that for a particular product, about 70% of the emissions come from raw materials, 9% from the label and 8% from energy consumption during production.

This data allows us to determine the crucial parameters affecting the carbon footprint, which then enables us to make



Kotronis has a long tradition of training and developing new employees, which contributes substantially to the welfare of the community.

appropriate decisions and provide our customers with concrete and sustainable solutions. Additionally, the EPD is the formal environmental declaration on which our customers can base credible sustainability claims without the risk of greenwashing. Therefore, it is important for us to deliver reliable and verified information.

**Your company describes itself as based on the pillars of leadership, innovation and development. Have these values changed over time?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** Leadership is always a personal matter. There are fundamental principles that we follow, but they must align with one's own beliefs and personal philosophy. In our company, we pursue a quiet leadership style. We maintain a close relationship with our employees and prioritise their confidence in their roles. It's important to us that our team feels comfortable sharing their ideas and concerns openly, knowing they can bring them to the table at any time.

Innovation and development are central components of our company and, as a family business, we want to grow together with our employees. We are always striving to identify areas of improvement – with a particular focus on our processes. When you internalise this mindset, development

and progress come naturally. However, without continuous growth, the necessary resources and economic strength to implement all these ideas would be lacking.

**KIMA 4.0 is another of your current projects that I discovered while preparing for this interview. What's that about?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** KIMA (Kotronis Interconnection of Manufacturing Assets) is a project that belongs to the Industry 4.0 era. We had already started working in this direction before it became a trend. Essentially, it's an advanced planning system that we have installed in all our machines, and it is already running successfully. It monitors in real-time all phases of the production process, significantly improving our production planning. Since we have thousands of different labels, planning can be very demanding. Without accurate real-time information, it is challenging to combine all orders efficiently. KIMA helps minimise communication between departments and ensures that we know exactly when something will be completed. The system also takes

maintenance requirements into account, further optimising our operations.

**You strive to build stable and long-term partnerships with your customers. To what extent does this also apply to your suppliers?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** Long-term, stable relationships are of great importance to us, both with our customers and our suppliers. Producing thin-walled packaging is a very complex process, with many special requirements that vary from customer to customer. When you work with a new supplier, it takes some time before you can collaborate efficiently.

Having trust in your partner is crucial. Without trust, you can't take risks, and remaining on the

safe side will not lead to progress. However, if we work with a company that has solid technical expertise and proposes new solutions, we can be confident that good solutions will be found. You can't afford to buy expensive equipment while also risking that a project will fail.

**"THE ENVIRONMENTAL  
PRODUCT DECLARATION ALLOWS  
US TO ACCURATELY CALCULATE  
THE ECOLOGICAL FOOTPRINT  
OF EACH OF OUR PRODUCTS."**

**Augustinos Kotronis, CEO Kotronis Packaging**



As a family business in its second generation, Kotronis wants to continue to grow together with its employees.

**You have been working with Otto Hofstetter AG for about ten years now. How did this come about?**

**Lefteris Antonakakis:** We have been manufacturing many moulds ourselves since 2006, but to grow further, we decided to purchase moulds externally as well. Otto Hofstetter AG was known to us for its technical expertise and precision manufacturing. What was particularly important to us were the open discussions and the competent staff that facilitated these conversations. I attended the first meetings in Uznach and was very pleased with the technical details they shared with us. In 2016, we put the first mould from Uznach into operation, and now we have seven moulds from Otto Hofstetter AG. We enjoy a trusting relationship with the company and we value their technical support, as well as the opportunity to discuss sensitive issues and special solutions. Maintenance by Otto Hofstetter AG is essential for us, since it is complex and must be carried out by experts.

**To what extent is it relevant for you as a family business that Otto Hofstetter AG is also a family-owned and family-run company?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** It is particularly important for us to have a supplier that is also owned and run by a family. This ensures a shared commitment to values and long-term objectives, as well as direct communication with the owner, fostering a close connection that positively impacts the communication between our teams. Benefits such as much faster decision-making and greater flexibility are also highly valuable to us.

**How could Otto Hofstetter AG better support you in achieving your goals?**

**Lefteris Antonakakis:** For one thing, it would be interesting for us to receive information about the ecological footprint of the moulds so that we can factor this data into our calculations regarding the environmental impact of our own products. For another, reducing delivery times would be advantageous and would provide us with a significant competitive edge. We also greatly appreciate the technical support and consulting expertise of the company, so it's important to us to have regular exchanges of ideas and technical know-how.

**Where is our industry and plastics in general heading?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** I believe it's important to establish a solid foundation of data by accurately calculating the carbon footprint and emissions of our processes and comparing

them to alternatives. At Kotronis, we are doing our part by pursuing sustainability targets and striving to contribute to our society and our industry. Nevertheless, we cannot influence the central issues in a meaningful way. We still believe that PP plastic packaging has excellent properties in terms of its overall footprint and functionality.

There are interesting initiatives now underway that promote the mechanical recycling of food packaging and improve its recyclability and reprocessing. Our industry is working to ensure we don't switch to alternatives only to find out that they are impractical or inappropriate. In some cases, there may be

better alternatives, but in the realm of food packaging, we believe plastic remains the best solution. It is also crucial that consumers recognise the true value of plastic and improve their handling of it. If they are well informed and encouraged to do so, they will certainly make an effort.

**In conclusion, where do you see Kotronis in the next five to seven years?**

**Augustinos Kotronis:** Our goal is to continue growing and to be there for our customers over the long term. We intend to invest in talented young people that will accompany us on this journey, and we remain open to pursuing new business opportunities. Sustainability and close collaboration with our customers will continue to be at the core of our work.

**Thank you very much for the interview, gentlemen. We wish you and your team continued success and look forward to more positive news from Kotronis.**

**"WE BELIEVE PLASTIC  
REMAINS THE BEST  
SOLUTION FOR  
FOOD PACKAGING."**

**Augustinos Kotronis, CEO Kotronis Packaging**



Kotronis Packaging  
www.kotronis.gr, info@kotronis.gr

Founded: 1971  
Specialist in: Thin-walled packaging and lids designed for the food industry, with in-mould labelling  
Applications: Deli products, butter, sweet spreads, ice cream and other products in the FMCG market.

Malamata, Efpalio, Fokida, 33056, Greece

# POWERDUO.

Driven by increasing demand for larger volumes of drinking water, the **market for home and office delivery (HOD)** is growing rapidly. At the same time, health concerns about polycarbonates are accelerating **a switch to PET**. Unfortunately, there have been few good options on the market that are specifically tailored to meet the production **demands of large-volume PET preforms**. But now, **Otto Hofstetter AG and Otto Systems have joined forces** to create a fully optimised production solution for this growing market segment.

Driven by increasing demand for larger volumes of drinking water, the market for home and office delivery (HOD) is growing rapidly. At the same time, health concerns about polycarbonates are accelerating a switch to PET. Unfortunately, there have been few good options on the market that are specifically tailored to meet the production demands of large-volume PET preforms. But now, Otto Hofstetter AG and Otto Systems have joined forces to create a fully optimised production solution for this growing market segment.

Manufacturing PET preforms for the home and office delivery

(HOD) market involves some difficult technical challenges. For starters, the considerable wall thicknesses and the large volume of material they employ create a risk of waves or ribs forming during the injection process. In addition, deformations such as ovality or crystallinity can also arise, which can noticeably impair the mechanical and visual integrity of the plastic and lead to problems in the subsequent stretch-and-blow moulding process. Thus, the unusual dimensions of HOD preforms require a specialised solution. Until now, the systems available for producing PET preforms for HOD containers have been at best only partially designed for this demanding application.



### **Moulds from the best source.**

Now, PET preform manufacturers for the HOD sector have a better choice. They can use the new, fully optimised production system for HOD containers from Otto Hofstetter AG and Otto Systems.

It all starts with Otto Hofstetter AG's new 8-cavity mould for HOD preforms, another example of the Swiss company's comprehensive expertise in PET preforms. The mould's exceptional cooling performance is achieved with OH-Xcool, our proprietary enhanced cooling channel that smoothly and quickly dissipates the considerable heat the process generates. In addition, the new mould's sliding surfaces are coated with OH-Xtreme, the low-friction, no-maintenance coating that has demonstrated its advantages for years on moulds for small-volume PET preforms, assuring high quality and efficiency and a long service life. The new HOD moulds are also equipped with Otto Hofstetter's proprietary Cavity Lock technology, which further increases the service life of the moulds while reducing maintenance.

The high-precision positioning of the stack inserts ensures virtually seamless operation. In combination with OH-Xtreme, the technology helps to ensure consistent performance over millions of cycles while at the same time significantly extending the service life of the moulds. The hot runner has also been adapted to the special requirements of HOD preforms. In order to ensure optimal yet gentle material distribution as well as ideal process conditions, the channels have been revised to optimise their flow properties.

### **A jewel of a mould needs the right setting.**

The full potential of this new mould for HOD preforms is fully exploited in combination with the HOD-Series 160 production line engineered by Otto Systems, the sister company of Otto Hofstetter AG. The synergy between the mould and the production system delivers the efficient production of PET preforms for large-volume containers.

The HOD-Series 160 from Otto Systems features a range of innovative technical solutions. For example, it has a unique, outward-bending, electrically operated toggle lever mechanism that enables highly dynamic movements with minimal energy consumption. By lengthening the toggle levers, the columns and the machine bed, opening strokes of almost one metre are achieved. In addition, the high-performance plasticisation stands out, ideally balancing the plasticising and the injection processes.

Some other decisive developments in this system include the plasticising screw, which smoothly plasticises unusually high shot weights, and what is known as the Time Safe Unit (TSU). This component handles the substantial and prolonged pressure conditions required by large preforms. This means that the screw can ensure long dosing strokes with an ideal dwell time at a moderate speed. The optimised coordination of this step is vital and this extremely compact solution guarantees optimal process conditions.

### **Fit for special cases.**

Another outstanding feature of the HOD-Series 160 from Otto Systems is the unique post-cooling arrangement with 2+2 stations. The compact design of the mould and the clever placement of the removal plate make it possible to increase the number of post-cooling cycles from two to four. The width of the removal plate was doubled to accommodate eight rows of water-cooled sleeves. Together with the Pick-Blow combi system for internal preform air cooling, optimal shaping is achieved. This concept enables faster cycle times and increases efficiency in the production of heavy and thick-walled HOD preforms.

### **Production efficiency.**

The HOD-Series 160, equipped with the 8-cavity injection mould from Otto Hofstetter AG, offers PET manufacturers impressive technical specifications and performance. Preforms are produced for a 5-gallon disposable container (19 litres) with a snap-on mouth with a diameter of 55 millimetres. With an inner diameter of 46 millimetres. and wall thicknesses of over 6 millimetres., the preform weighs 330 grams. The 160-ton system with 4100-TSU-100 achieves an average cycle time of 35 seconds, which is significantly faster than current offerings on the market.

### **Ready for an infinite variety of applications.**

The combination of the 8-cavity HOD mould from Otto Hofstetter AG and the HOD-Series 160 from Otto Systems marks a significant step forward in the efficient production of large-volume PET containers. The possibilities of this power duo are very broad. Weights, necks and base geometries can be tailored and optimised to the specific application. The HOD Series concept shows how engineering expertise combined with in-depth industry knowledge can master complex challenges in today's modern production. Applications for beer kegs or containers for agrochemicals and other technical products are also possible with this solution.

# STANDARD- SETTER.

He devotes much of his free time to breeding **Orpington chickens** and is a **serious connoisseur of wine**, too. During the week, however, his full attention is on producing the famous injection moulds at Otto Hofstetter AG. **Jules Müller has been in charge of production for eight years and leads a team of over a hundred colleagues.** He compares his role to that of a coach who – if the situation requires it – joins the team and lends a hand.



### **Jules Müller, why are we meeting at your chicken coop?**

Breeding chickens is a hobby of mine. It's something that has fascinated me for a long time and this is where I go to find my daily balance. I started twelve years ago. After a couple of false starts with other breeds, I finally found "my" chicken, the Orpingtons. This calm, large and robust breed has a friendly nature that suits me well. It's a chicken that also corresponds to my visual expectations because it conforms to certain ideals of beauty. For me, breeding is not just a hobby, but also a form of relaxation.

### **What is your relationship generally with animals?**

Since childhood, I have always had animals around me. During my younger years, I travelled a lot as I pursued my professional training. I had to put my hobby on hold. Animals are always honest and authentic and each animal has its own personality. That fascinates me. Even though I used to have other small animals, I have always been drawn to poultry. When we found the right house, I was able to fulfil my dream and breed them.

### **What else do you do in your free time?**

I enjoy spending time with my family. We like to go skiing – and luckily many good ski areas are within easy reach of our home. Another source of pleasure for me is a good glass of red wine. The fine differences in the craft can be decisive to the quality of a wine. I'm part of a small group of colleagues who meet four times a year for an evening wine-tasting. Personally, I particularly prefer wines from the Spanish regions of Rioja and Ribera del Duero. Travelling is also something I enjoy a lot. Every year we go on several short or long trips, for example to the Palatinate region of Germany, or Vienna or the Italian-Swiss canton of Ticino. I've also travelled to South America, Australia and New Zealand.

### **What is your favourite travel destination?**

I'm fascinated by other cultures, so I have to say the whole world is my favourite travel destination. I would love to travel to every country, because each one has its own special wonders. It's important to travel with open eyes and see the beauty of the world. However, mass tourism does not appeal to me. I want to get to know the people, eat where the locals eat, and really experience the culture.

### **You live in Kaltbrunn, work in Uznach and grew up in Näfels, all communities that are close to each other. What does this region mean to you?**

This region, which we call the Linth Plain, means home

to me. My roots are here, and we have everything you could wish for: Mediterranean flair, high alpine mountains, clean lakes and rivers, and very good transportation links. With no natural resources and a lot of marshlands, this area used to be very poor. People here could only get ahead through hard work, and this gritty mentality is still noticeable today.

**The majority of employees at Otto Hofstetter AG come from nearby. To what extent does this characteristic influence the work?**

The solidarity and the willingness to go the extra mile for customers are strong characteristics that can be felt throughout all of our teams. There's a natural spirit of togetherness that people from this region are probably born with, along with the will to overcome challenges. This makes many things possible and, I think, is a significant benefit for our customers. Our stubborn focus on problem-solving and quality may go unnoticed, but it's second nature for us.

**You are a production manager at OHAG. What are the similarities between running a chicken coop and a factory workshop?**

There are certainly some parallels. Both breeding and production are about continuous improvement and the selection of suitable groups that work together harmoniously and are jointly responsible for the next generation. As with my

breeding chickens, I also attach great importance to excellent training at the company for the apprentices. Both the chickens and the employees need an environment in which they feel comfortable and can develop.

**How do you explain your role at OHAG to an outsider?**

That's easily summarised. As a production manager, I manage production. That sounds very simple, but there's quite a lot to it. I see myself as a coach for my team. We are all individuals with different ambitions and needs. In addition to professional coaching, interpersonal situations are also an important part of my role. I see my responsibility as meeting the requirements of our customers in every respect together with my teams.

**What does a typical working day look like for you?**

My days are very varied. I usually start between 6:30 and 6:45 in the morning. My tasks include preparing for regular meetings, design meetings and deadline meetings as well as evaluating new machines and processes. But employee discussions and problem-solving are also always on my agenda. If necessary, I'm also ready to jump in and work on the production line, too. I do whatever I can to support my teams.

**Moulds sold all over the world are created under your supervision. What do you know about Otto Hofstetter**

## JULES MÜLLER

Head of Production and "coach" of over a hundred employees at Otto Hofstetter AG. Gained valuable professional experience in various positions over three decades before coming to Uznach on 1 May 2016.



### AG's reputation in the industry?

In production, we rarely have direct customer contact. But we know from our colleagues and from management that our moulds enjoy an excellent reputation. Otto Hofstetter AG is well known for its durable and high-performance moulds, which many consider to be the benchmark in the industry. From my previous jobs, I can say that we also enjoy a lot of respect from our competitors. In the field of chicken farming, you would say that we are the standard-setters.

**"IN ADDITION TO  
PROFESSIONAL COACHING,  
INTERPERSONAL SITUATIONS  
ARE ALSO AN IMPORTANT  
PART OF MY ROLE"**

Jules Müller, Head of Production

### After the design and specification steps, the actual production of a mould obviously plays a major role in its final quality. How do you ensure that quality is always at the highest level?

Our engaged, motivated employees embrace the high quality standards at Otto Hofstetter AG. And team spirit is strong, which means we can achieve a lot. In addition to the modern machinery we have at our disposal, precise and seamless communication is essential to achieve the best results. And, of course, it is important for errors to be avoided or minimised right from the start.

### How do you motivate your teams when additional work needs to be done?

My teams know their goals and usually organise themselves when additional work is required. If something is urgent or a bottleneck emerges, I'm there with them to support them. I think my people appreciate that. With our good communication as a group, I know I can count on everyone rowing in the same direction.

### How has your role changed in the eight years as operations manager?

The technological changes in our area have been manageable in recent years. However, digitalisation and the shortage of skilled workers do pose challenges for us. We will probably have no choice but to face up to these challenges and further exploit the possibilities of modern automation and digitalisation. This will make processes more efficient while at the same time compensating for the shortage of skilled workers.

### What stops have you made during your professional career?

I completed my apprenticeship with a mould maker in Näfels, Switzerland. Thereafter, I worked for another five years to

complete my training as a federally certified master mechanic. This was followed by a year at Kunststoff Schwanden, five years at a precision mechanics company in Zurich and another five years at a mould maker in the Schaffhausen area. After the birth of my first son, I returned to Näfels and

took on the role as production manager at Otto Hofstetter AG, before moving to Uznach five years later.

### What do you think of the wave of digitalisation and automation that industry is experiencing?

Technological change is advancing rapidly today, no doubt, and it's up to us not to miss the boat. Automation has been good for us for a long time. But, that said, with growing digitalisation it is important to weigh the benefits versus the costs. As a rule of thumb, I think keeping something as simple as possible ensures that it will be used.

### What goals do you want to achieve as a plant manager in the near future?

Producing our moulds must be regarded as an attractive profession by the next generation. To do this, we have to use smart, digitally networked, easy-to-use processing machines. The upstream and downstream processes must also be continuously improved in order to continue meeting our high quality standards. This is the only way to ensure the long-term satisfaction of existing and future customers.

### And privately?

My aim is to stay healthy and accompany my children into the future.

### Thank you for the interview and all the best for the future.





TOTALLY SWISS.



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